The period of political uncertainty in Junagarh meant that the lions of Gir suffered. With the Nawab's protection crumbling, several lions were hunted down in the later months of 1947. It is said that some of the hunters were princes of neighbouring principalities who simply took advantage of the confusion to add to their private collections. Thankfully, order was restored by early 1948. This was not merely an act of wildlife conservation. The lion, as depicted on the Mauryan pillar in Sarnath, was now the national emblem. There had been some who argued in favour of the elephant but a committee headed by future president Rajendra Prasad had ruled in favour of the lion in July 1947. The same committee also decided that the flag of the Indian National Congress would be adopted as the national flag after replacing the symbol of the 'charkha' (spinning wheel) with that of the spoked wheel from the same Mauryan column—the ancient symbol of the Chakravartin or Universal Monarch. After thousands of years, Sudas's dream was still alive.

Even as the Junagarh crisis was being resolved, a fresh crisis was brewing in Hyderabad, a leftover from Aurangzeb's invasion of southern India. It was the largest of the princely states and its ruler Nizam Osman Ali Khan was famous as one of the richest and most miserly men in the world. Although the state had an overwhelming Hindu majority, the Muslims dominated the police, civil service and the landowning nobility. It even had a sizeable army that included armoured units as well as Arab and Afghan mercenaries. Faced with the withdrawal of the British, the Nizam first attempted to negotiate some form of independence and then hinted that he would opt for Pakistan.

The threat was never really tenable since Hyderabad was a landlocked state surrounded by Indian territory. Still, the Nizam was persuaded by Kasim Razvi, an Islamic fanatic, to allow the creation of an irregular paramilitary group called the Razakdars, which had 200,000 members at its height. As the political situation deteriorated, the Razakdars unleashed a reign of terror in the countryside. India responded by tightening an economic blockade. Finally in September 1948, more than a year after independence, Deputy Prime Minister Patel decided to move. The military